

Module 12: Managing your audit team

Managing Your Audit Team

1. Importance of Team Coordination:

- a. Ensure the audit team works cohesively to meet audit objectives.
- b. Support less experienced auditors with guidance, and help experienced auditors align with the current audit plan.

2. Pre-Audit Preparation:

- c. Start managing the team before the audit begins by discussing the audit scope, criteria, and objectives with the certification body and audit client.
- d. Fully understand the audit objectives to direct the team effectively.

3. Knowing Your Team:

- e. Assess each team member's strengths, weaknesses, and skills.
- f. Assign tasks based on each auditor's competencies to optimize performance.

4. Role Clarity and Leadership:

- g. Clearly define each auditor's role within the audit plan to prevent misalignment.
- h. Balance guidance with autonomy by providing a structured plan that allows auditors flexibility within defined parameters.

5. Structured Planning and Flexibility:

- i. Create an audit framework that allows auditors freedom, such as choosing specific areas for site visits.

6. Benefits of Strong Leadership:

- j. Good leadership, planning, and organization enhance team motivation and efficiency.
- k. Instills confidence in the audit client that the process is valuable and professionally managed.

Pre-Audit Team Communication

1. Team Preparation:

- a. Review team members' experience and knowledge, either via CVs/profiles or through discussion of their relevant auditing background.
- b. Conduct a meeting (in-person or remote) to review key topics and gather input.

2. Key Discussion Topics:

- c. Audit Objectives, Scope, and Criteria: Outline what the audit will cover.
- d. Team Roles and Methods: Explain planned auditor activities, audit methods, and any remote auditing techniques.
- e. Logistics: Discuss travel, accommodation, workspaces, and safety equipment needs.
- f. Audit Risks: Address risks such as security protocols, confidentiality, and business processes.

3. Documentation and Information Needs:

- g. Identify any information or documents needed in advance (e.g., org charts, previous non-conformity closures, schematics).
- h. Consider reviewing these documents off-site or request them early for on-site availability.

4. Final Plan Development:

- i. Hold this meeting before discussing the audit plan with the client to gather insights for planning.
- j. Notify the team of the final audit plan and any changes after the client discussion.

Managing the Audit Process

1. Audit Management Flexibility:

- a. Adjust the formality of management based on the audit's nature, team procedures, and personal experience.

2. Key Information to Track:

- b. Evidence requests (pending and received).
- c. Documents reviewed, interview and site visit progress.
- d. Audit plan status and amendments.
- e. Questions raised and answered, audit evidence, and findings.

3. Information Management Tools:

- f. Use shared documents, software, flip charts, post-its, or templates to organize and coordinate information.

4. On-Site Audit Steps:

Opening meeting.

- g. Evidence gathering (site visits, interviews, document reviews).
- h. Form audit findings and assess for non-conformities.
- i. Draw audit conclusions (does the organization meet standards?).
- j. Prepare and conduct the closing meeting.

5. Time Allocation:

- k. Allocate most time (75%) to evidence gathering.
- l. Plan time for evaluating evidence, agreeing on findings, and preparing the closing presentation.

6. Closing Preparation Timing:

- m. Work backward from closing time to allocate sufficient time for each step.
Example: Closing at 5 p.m., with a 1-hour presentation, requires starting at 4 p.m.
- n. Factor in presentation preparation time based on your efficiency.

7. Presentation Preparation:

- o. Allow ample time for preparing visuals or media (photos, slides).
- p. Consider preparing materials daily if needed for better quality.

Team Meetings

- a. Team Meetings: Held at least once a day to:
- b. Review and update audit information.
- c. Plan upcoming activities.
- d. Discuss any necessary changes to the audit plan.
- e. Debriefing Sessions: Separate from team meetings, with the audit client:
- f. Manage the audit process.
- g. Share information and maintain communication.
- h. Difference: Ensure the audit team understands the distinction:
- i. Team meetings focus on internal audit discussions and planning.
- j. Debriefing sessions are for client communication and process management.

Managing audit findings:

1. Use a Template: Develop a consistent template for documenting audit findings. Include:
 - a. Description of the non-conformity.
 - b. Supporting evidence (e.g., photos, documents, interviews).
 - c. Criteria the non-conformity applies to.
2. Ensure Consistency: Regularly discuss and review findings within the audit team to maintain consistency in reporting.
3. Draft Findings: Treat findings as drafts until the debriefing session with the audit client. This allows for clarification and additional evidence.
4. Debriefing Sessions: Always review findings with the audit client before finalizing conclusions. This helps avoid mistakes and ensures clear understanding.
5. Client Objections: Allow the audit client to raise objections, even if they disagree with findings. Document any objections in the final report.

Managing audit records:

1. Balance Documentation: Maintain only necessary records to avoid excessive documentation. Use creative methods like digital photographs instead of paper copies for easier management.
2. Types of Audit Documentation: Key documents include:
 - d. Audit plans, reports, and non-conformity reports.
 - e. Auditor notes, photographs, and lists of evidence (e.g., reviewed documents or interviews).
 - f. Post-audit records like corrective actions and follow-up audits.
3. Collecting Audit Records: Lead auditors may use shared files, software, or cloud storage to collect records. A separate list with unique references can help organize the records.
4. Monitor Compliance: Regularly check that auditors follow the record-keeping process and address any issues in team meetings.

What to do when you hit problems?

1. Assess the Impact: Understand how the problem affects the audit objectives. Decide on appropriate actions based on the issue at hand.
2. Local Solutions: Start by addressing the problem locally with the auditee and audit client. This may involve:
 - g. Adjusting the audit plan.
 - h. Reallocating auditee members or rescheduling activities.
3. Maintain Audit Objectives: Try to meet the objectives without changing the scope or criteria. If that's not possible, contact the certification body to discuss potential changes, like:
 - i. Adjusting audit duration.
 - j. Reducing the scope or changing criteria.
 - k. Switching to remote auditing or off-site methods.
4. Re-evaluate Objectives: If the audit objectives are still at risk, discuss with the certification body and audit client to possibly modify the objectives, scope, or criteria.
5. Postpone or Cancel: If achieving the audit objectives is impossible, consider postponing or cancelling the audit. Make this decision only after consulting with the certification body and audit client.

Evaluating your audit management:

1. Self-Reflection: Consider how well you managed the audit team, kept the process on track, and developed good relationships. Ask yourself:
 - l. Did you leverage the team's strengths?
 - m. How effectively did you manage interactions with the audit client and auditees?
 - n. Was your communication clear with all parties?
2. Evaluate Key Areas: Reflect on:
 - o. The effectiveness of your closing meeting.
 - p. The accuracy and value of your audit conclusions.
3. Seek Feedback: Ask for feedback from the audit client, auditees, or audit team members to get an external perspective on your performance.
4. Continuous Improvement: Use the feedback to identify areas for growth. Recognize both your strengths and areas for improvement.

By asking the right questions and being open to feedback, you can continuously improve your lead auditor skills.